FIELD GUIDE · NO. 7

Trees of the Northern Ridge

A walker's companion to the twelve species you will meet between the trailhead and the summit, with notes on bark, leaf and season.



Ridge Trust · Second edition

BEFORE YOU GO

How to use this guide

Each species gets a single spread: a description on the left, and on the right the details that matter when you are standing in front of a trunk with no leaves to go on. Start with the bark. It is the one feature every tree shows in every season, and with a little practice it is enough to tell most of the ridge apart.

Leaves come next. Look at their arrangement on the twig before their shape: opposite or alternate narrows the field faster than any outline. Then the overall form of the crown, which you can read from a distance, and finally the seeds, which are often lying on the path long after the tree has dropped them.

The ridge climbs from 300 to 1,150 metres, and the forest changes with it. Oak and hazel give way to beech, then to birch and rowan, and the last few hundred metres belong to the pines. The table on the next page shows where to expect each.

Distances in this guide are measured from the lower car park. Heights are approximate and the trees, of course, have not read them.

> *“Start with the bark. It is the one feature every tree shows in every season.”*

AT A GLANCE

Where they grow

Species	Altitude	Bark	Leaves
Sessile oak	300–600 m	Grey, deep ridges	Lobed, alternate
Hazel	300–550 m	Copper, peeling	Round, toothed
Ash	300–500 m	Pale, diamond net	Pinnate, opposite
Beech	450–800 m	Smooth, silver	Oval, wavy edge
Holly	400–750 m	Smooth, green-grey	Spiny, glossy
Silver birch	600–1,000 m	White, black diamonds	Triangular
Rowan	650–1,050 m	Shiny, grey	Pinnate, alternate
Scots pine	800–1,150 m	Orange plates above	Paired needles



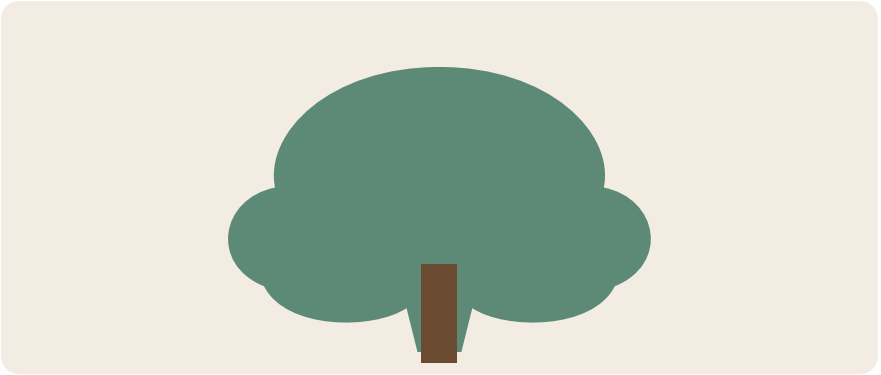
Altitude ranges along the main trail. Scots pine (not shown) takes over above 800 m.

SPECIES 1

Sessile oak

The oaks of the lower slopes are sessile oaks, named for their acorns, which sit directly on the twig rather than hanging from long stalks. They are the oldest trees on the ridge: several near the first stile were mature when the field walls were built.

In winter, look for the deeply ridged grey bark and the clusters of buds at the tips of the twigs. In spring the leaves open late, a soft bronze at first, and the canopy stays open enough for bluebells to carpet the ground beneath.



A broad, irregular crown. Lower branches often reach out almost horizontally.

An oak supports more life than any other native tree: hundreds of insects, the birds that feed on them, and the lichens and mosses that cover the north side of every trunk on this damp slope.

SPECIES 2

Beech

Above the oaks, the beeches begin, and the forest floor changes with them. Beech leaves cast a deep shade and rot slowly, so the ground beneath is a quiet layer of copper leaves with little growing through it.

The bark is the easiest on the ridge to recognise: smooth, silver-grey and cool to the touch, like the skin of an elephant. Young beeches keep their dead leaves through the winter, rustling pale brown long after everything else is bare.

> *“Smooth, silver-grey and cool to the touch.”*

Beech nuts, called mast, fall in triangular pairs from spiny husks. In good years, every few autumns, they cover the path and the jays and squirrels spend weeks carrying them away.

SPECIES 3

Scots pine

The last trees before the summit are Scots pines, and they are unmistakable from far below: tall, bare trunks topped with flat, dark crowns. Their bark is grey and plated near the ground and a warm orange higher up, glowing in evening light.

The needles come in pairs, twisted slightly, a blue-green that stays the same all year. The cones take two years to ripen and open on dry days to release their winged seeds.

Above the pines the ground is heather and rock. Turn around here: on a clear day you can see the whole of the forest you have climbed through, laid out in bands of colour from the valley floor.

THANK YOU FOR WALKING WITH US

Stay on the marked paths, close the gates behind you, and leave the ridge as you found it.